you to arrange elements using HTML tables, as is customary, and may jumble your content. Because the content is separated from the layout code, you could create a Lynx-friendly version of an entire site by creating a single layout module.

9.7 URLS FRIENDLY TO SEARCH ENGINES

Search engines such as Google and Alta Vista attempt to explore the entire Web. They have become an essential resource for Internet users, and anyone who maintains a public site benefits from being listed. Search engines use robots, or spiders, to explore pages in a Web site, and they index PHP scripts the same way they index HTML files. When links appear in a page, they are followed. Consequently, the entire site becomes searchable.

Unfortunately, robots will not follow links that appear to contain form variables. Links containing question marks may lead a robot into an endless loop, so they are programmed to avoid them. This presents a problem for sites that use form variables in links. Passing form variables in anchor tags is a natural way for PHP to communicate, but it can keep your pages out of the search engines. To overcome this problem, data must be passed in a format that resembles URLs.

First, consider how a Web server accepts a URI and matches it to a file. The URI is a virtual path, the part of the URL that comes after the host name. It begins with a slash and may be followed by a directory, another slash, and so forth. One by one, the Web server matches directories in the URI to directories in the filesystem. A script is executed when it matches part of the URI, even when more path information follows. Ordinarily this extra path information is thrown away, but you can capture it.

Look at Listing 3. This script works with Apache compiled for UNIX but may not work with other Web servers. It relies on the PATH_INFO environment variable, which may not be present in a different context. Each Web server creates a unique set of environment variables, although there is overlap.

You may be accessing the code in Listing 3 from the URL http://localhost/corephp/figures/21-5.php/1234.html. In this case, you are connecting to a local server that contains a directory named corephp/figures in its document root. A default installation of Apache might place this in /usr/local/apcache/htdocs. The name of the script is 21-5.php, and everything after the script name is then placed in the PATH_INFO variable. No file named 1234.html exists, but to the Web browser it appears to be an ordinary HTML document. It appears that way to a spider as well.